Instead, he just smashed the ball in at the near post, into the roof of the net. All the United side of the ground erupted. Giggsy was running along in front of them, waving his shirt in the air. Loads of the supporters were spilling onto the field. I got to him, too, and I can still remember the smell of the fans around us: one bloke, in particular, must have been chain-smoking the whole game and he grabbed hold of me. I couldn't get the smell of his cigarette smoke off my shirt and out of my nostrils for the rest of the game.

When the final whistle went, United supporters came pouring onto the field again and it got a bit scary for a while. I got lifted up onto some people's shoulders. Someone was trying to pull one of my boots off as a souvenir; someone else had hold of my shirt. I leaned over in all the din and tried to say to one of the fans who was carrying me: 'While you've got me up here on your shoulders, could we try and head over towards where the dressing rooms are?'

Like I say, it was a little frightening; and I was out on the field for what seemed like ages. I think I was the last person off. I was enjoying the moment, though. Times like that don't come along too often, even if you're playing for United, and I just wanted to experience it all. Finally, I managed to find my way back to the dressing rooms. The atmosphere was fantastic but completely different to the madness outside. No jumping around, no shouting: everybody, the manager included, was just sitting there, glowing. Something special had just happened. It was about as good a game of soccer as I'd ever played in. Right up there, as it turned out, with our next semi-final which came along the following Wednesday night.

We hadn't played well in the first leg of the Champions League semi against Juventus. They'd come to Old Trafford and got a 1–1 draw, which was almost as good as a victory because of the away goal. We had to win in Turin now. Nobody was ever supposed to win in Turin. Five minutes into the game, Juventus were 1–0 up and battering us. After ten, they were 2–0 up and still battering us. I found myself thinking back to those semi-finals against Dortmund and the chances we'd not taken. Was this going to turn out to be another year when we missed out on the final?

Sometimes in a game, when you're struggling, someone produces a moment of brilliance, like Ryan Giggs had at Villa Park, to turn everything on its head. Other times, it's the team as a whole that finds something, which was what happened in Turin. Maybe Juventus relaxed a little, I don't know, but we put a few passes together for the first time in the game. About twenty minutes had gone and we were still 2–0 down; but it didn't feel like we were out of it.